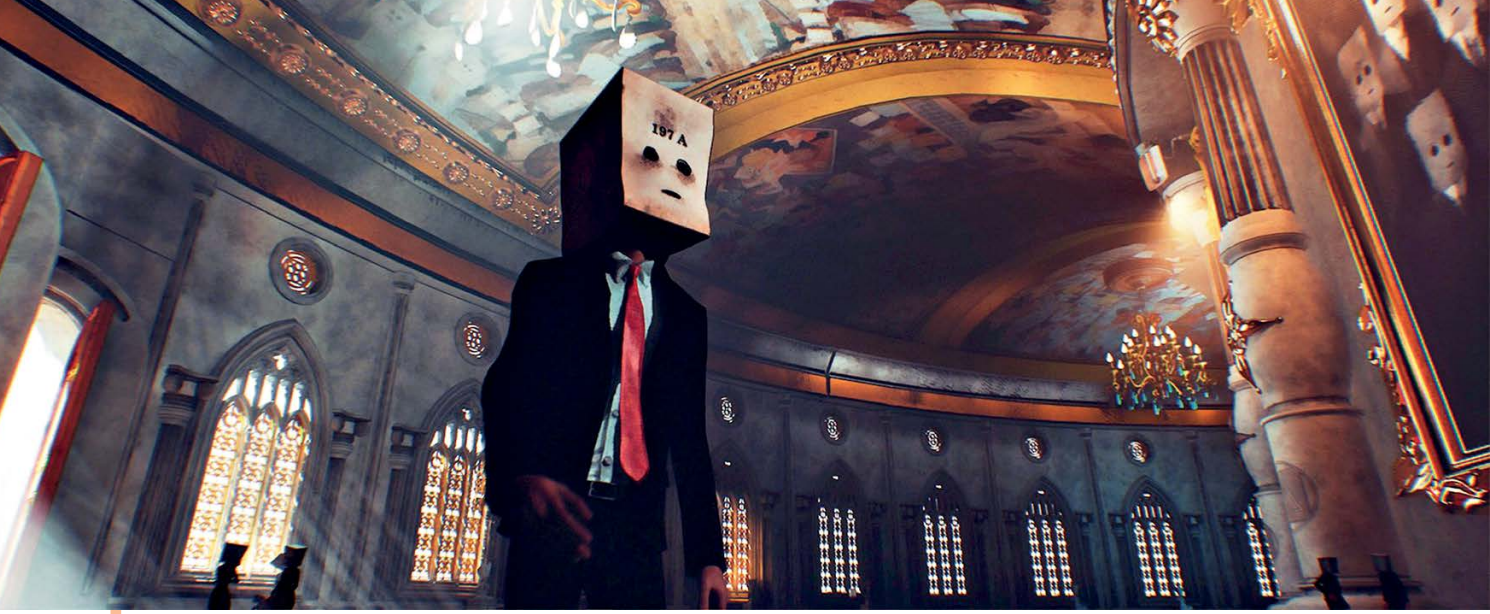


PROFILE

HOMEGROWN DYSTOPIA

Animator Ishan Shukla's 103-minute-long film *Schirkoa: In Lies We Trust*, which premiered at the International Film Festival Rotterdam, features an impressive global voice cast

While working in Singapore years ago, Ishan Shukla began doodling himself out of boredom. He had imagined a life of "creative jams and discussions", but as an animation professional, he found himself "a faceless, replaceable person no different from others".

One day, he replaced his head in his drawing with a box. Thus began Shukla's dystopian world of bag-heads, which has resulted in *Schirkoa: In Lies We Trust*. The 103-minute-long animated film premiered at the International Film Festival Rotterdam on January 28. The film is set in the fictional country of Schirkoa, where citizens are forced to wear a bag over their heads, thereby eliminating difference and individuality. The protagonist 197A is an average



THE JINN-BOT OF SHANTIPORT
by Samit Basu
TORDOTCOM
₹1,850; 416 pages

BOOKS

Interstellar Story

Samit Basu's latest novel–*The Jinn-Bot of Shantiport*–is a sci-fi take on the Aladdin story

South Asian speculative fiction, at its best, has always been a mash-up, a mixtape of tonal and percussive diversity, reflecting our own hybrid selves. As one of its foremost practitioners for the past two decades, Samit Basu's novels have always articulated this hybridity, moving seamlessly between sub-genres, narrative traditions and entire mythological universes. *The Jinn-Bot of Shantiport* will therefore feel comfortingly familiar to long-time readers–while also giving us yet another new and memorable addition to the canon of Indian and South Asian SF.

Shantiport is a once-glorious, now-decaying galactic backwater, where–after a period of internecine civil war–the Tiger Clan en-